The Words Behind “Level of Care”

A one-page sheet of plain meanings and what to write down for each.

“Supervision.” “Reassessment.” “Capabilities.” The words turn up as soon as a family starts planning ahead, and they sound more official than they are. Here are eighteen of them, each in a plain line or two, with what to note about Dad when one comes up.

The first two groups are standard terms, each defined from a public source. The third is the Family Care Roadmap's own working vocabulary. The definitions are for following the conversation. They aren't for sizing Dad up yourself.

Everyday help

Activities of daily living (ADLs)

Basic actions a person living independently performs every day: bathing, dressing, moving to and from a bed or a chair, eating, and caring for incontinence. [1]

WRITE DOWN Which ones Dad does himself, and any he gets a hand with.

Instrumental activities of daily living (IADLs)

Not needed for basic functioning, but needed to live independently: light housework, preparing and cleaning up after meals, taking medication, shopping, using the telephone and managing money. [1]

WRITE DOWN Who does each of these now.

Personal care (custodial care)

Non-skilled help with things like bathing, dressing, eating, getting in and out of a bed or chair, moving around and using the bathroom. [1]

WRITE DOWN Whether anyone gives Dad this kind of help today, and who.

Skilled care

Nursing care and therapies that usually require a licensed professional such as a nurse, doctor or therapist. [1]

WRITE DOWN Any nursing or therapy he has now, and who provides it.

Supervision

Someone being on hand to make sure a person is safe. The National Institute on Aging lists it alongside help with everyday activities as part of care at home. [2]

WRITE DOWN Supervision questions as questions, for a professional to answer. The family doesn't settle them.

Planning words you'll hear

Level of care

A phrase worth asking about when you hear it. In assisted living, the National Institute on Aging says, a few levels of care are typically offered, and exact arrangements vary by facility and by state. [3]

WRITE DOWN Who used the phrase and what they meant by it. It's fair to ask.

Setting

Where care is given. The National Institute on Aging says long-term care is provided in different places by different caregivers, depending on a person's needs. [2]

WRITE DOWN Nothing yet, unless someone raises one. Then note who raised it and the question you'd put to a professional.

Caregiver

Anyone who helps care for an older person or a person with a disability who lives at home. That may include you. [1]

WRITE DOWN Each person who helps Dad, and what they do.

Care manager (case manager)

A professional, usually with a background in counseling, social work or a related health care field, trained to assess a family's individual situation and to implement and monitor a care plan. [4]

WRITE DOWN Whether the family has spoken with one, and when.

Care plan

A form that summarizes a person's health conditions, specific care needs and current treatments. The CDC suggests updating it every year, or more often if health or medicines change. [5]

WRITE DOWN Whether one exists for Dad, who keeps it, and its date.

The Family Care Roadmap's working words

Care requirements

This step's name for the record of the help a person has today, task by task, with anything a professional has confirmed marked as such.

WRITE DOWN The tasks in Dad's week, what he does himself, and the help he gets.

Confirmed requirement

Something a professional on Dad's care team has said he needs, as distinct from something the family supposes.

WRITE DOWN What was said, who said it, and the date.

Open question

Anything about Dad's care that no professional has answered yet. It stays on the page as a question.

WRITE DOWN The question, and who it's for.

Reassessment

A professional taking a fresh look at how a person is managing. What it covers is the professional's to decide.

WRITE DOWN Who you'd ask for one: name, role and phone number.

Reassessment trigger

A change the family has agreed is worth raising with a professional. The family notices it. The professional says what it means.

WRITE DOWN The changes his doctor says they'd want to hear about, in the doctor's words.

Essential capability

Something any source of help would have to be able to do for Dad, once a professional has confirmed it.

WRITE DOWN Only the confirmed ones. The rest go under open questions.

Preference

What Dad would like, kept separate from what he needs and from what the family wishes for him.

WRITE DOWN His preferences, in his own words.

Caregiver capacity

What the people who help can realistically give. The Family Caregiver Alliance's questions for families include what kind of assistance you can provide yourself and whether a job affects the amount of care you can provide. [4]

WRITE DOWN What each person does now and can keep doing, in their own words.

What this sheet doesn't do

It defines words. It doesn't say which of them apply to Dad, how much help he needs or what he might need later. That's for the people who assess him.

Ready for the next step?

You know what the planning words mean and what to note under each. The care interview uses the same areas in plain language: it asks about Dad's daily life one area at a time and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The definitions in the first two groups come from the sources below. The third group is the Family Care Roadmap's own vocabulary and isn't taken from any of them, apart from the Family Caregiver Alliance's questions quoted under caregiver capacity. The advice about what to write down is ours.

1. Administration for Community Living, Glossary
2. National Institute on Aging, What Is Long-Term Care?
3. National Institute on Aging, Long-Term Care Facilities: Assisted Living, Nursing Homes, and Other Residential Care
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources
5. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan

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